

SC301 – Lecture 11 Mass Society and Mass Culture Debate: Summary

Key terms: *Culture / Popular Culture / Mass Society / Mass Culture / Folk Culture*

Introduction

Popular culture entered intellectual debate as a problem: a perceived threat to moral order, social authority, and democratic stability. It is still seen as a contemporary problem. Examples of this include:-

- The moral panic over music genres (Punk, Drill)
- Concerns about social media / smartphone use / 'Brian rot' memes
- Moralism concerning what children are reading (or not reading, debates on education about the teaching of English Literature / Latin in schools)
- Culture wars - that high culture is being driven out by popular culture
- Fears over populism / 'mob rule' / democratisation

This debate was concerned with mass society (industrialisation / urbanisation / capitalism / atomisation) had brought about mass culture (produced for the masses) which alongside mass democratisation and mass education would bring about civilisational decline.

The debate is best understood through the work of four key intellectual positions Matthew Arnold, F. R. Leavis (and Q. D. Leavis), and later sociological / cultural theorists, particularly Raymond Williams and Stuart Hall, who we will also discuss in lecture 14.

Culture and civilisation debate

Matthew Arnold

Matthew Arnold's *Culture and Anarchy* (1869) establishes the intellectual foundations of what later becomes known as the "**culture and civilisation**" tradition. Arnold defines culture as "the best that has been thought and said," a formulation that is explicitly hierarchical and normative. Culture, for Arnold, is not a description of everyday practices or popular tastes; it is a moral ideal. Arnold's fear is not simply social change, but what he calls "anarchy": the erosion of shared moral standards and the weakening of institutions capable of guiding collective life. Culture becomes a corrective to democracy rather than its expression. Rather than trusting popular opinion, Arnold argues that cultural authority should restrain and educate the masses. In this sense, culture functions as a form of moral governance, designed to compensate for the perceived dangers of mass democracy. Importantly, Arnold's critique targets not only the working class but also middle-class individualism and aristocratic rigidity; nevertheless, his framework assumes that cultural value must be defined by a minority with superior judgement. Arnold's solution is 'sweetness' and 'light' (intelligence of a certain, cultivated kind – light – to illuminate beauty – sweetness).

F. R. and Q. D. Leavis

F. R. Leavis develops the most influential and controversial version of this critique. In *Mass Civilisation and Minority Culture* (1930), In *Culture and Environment* (with Denys Thompson), Leavis frames literary education as a form of cultural defence: studying English literature becomes a means of cultivating moral discrimination and resisting the standardising effects of mass communication.

Q. D. Leavis complements this moral critique with an empirical analysis in *Fiction and the Reading Public* (1939). Examining publishing markets and readership patterns, she argues that commercial pressures transform literature into a commodity, privileging formulaic genres over serious fiction. While deeply pessimistic, her work anticipates later sociological concerns with cultural industries, commodification, and audience formation (see also Frankfurt school, lecture 12 for a Marxist critique). Together, the Leavises present mass culture as a symptom of social decline and position cultural elites, and a particular form of education, as necessary guardians of value.

Possible Critiques

- a. Taste is not objective and a matter of cultural judgement, rooted in class inequalities (Bourdieu)
- b. 'Culture is ordinary' (Raymond Williams) and not just the preserve of a elite class.
- c. Popular culture is negotiated / produced in varying media conditions of governance and regulation.
- d. Popular culture is not always 'mass culture' and is fragmented and can reflect 'folk cultures'

Stuart Hall

Hall does not deny that culture is shaped by power, capitalism, and inequality. Instead, he challenges the assumption that popular culture is either a degraded mass product or an authentic expression of "the people." In "Notes on Deconstructing 'the Popular,'" Hall reconceptualises popular culture as a contested terrain, a site of ongoing struggle between dominant institutions and subordinate groups. Hall's intervention breaks with classical mass culture theory in two ways. First, he rejects the idea of passive audiences. Drawing on reception theory, Hall argues that media texts are polysemic: they can be interpreted in dominant, negotiated, or oppositional ways depending on social position and experience. Second, he introduces the idea of relative autonomy. Culture operates within structural constraints but is never fully determined by them.